Red Card

By S.L. Gilbow

NARRATOR: **(Pg 11-22)** Late one April evening, Linda Jackson pulled a revolver from her purse and shot her husband through a large mustard stain in the center of his T-shirt. The official after incident survey concluded that almost all of Merry Valley approved of the shooting. Sixty-four percent of the townspeople even rated her target selection as "excellent."

ANDREWS: He never seemed to have a good word to say about anybody.

BLANCHARD: Excellent use of a bullet. Most overbearing person I've ever met. He deserved what he got.

INTRODUCTION

Welcome to the future. In an effort to curb uncontrolled violence and a drastic rise of murder, America has outlawed all weapons. Well, almost all . . .

In this dystopian future, our government has chosen to issue (at random) special cards. Red cards. Along with each of these cards comes a government issued handgun. The red card holder has a single use permit to kill any one person, at any time, for any reason with full immunity from prosecution.

And Linda Jackson holds a . . . Red Card by S.L. Gilbow

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NARRATOR: Linda knew what to do after shooting Larry. She had read The Enforcement Handbook from cover to cover six times. So, after she shot her husband, Linda returned the revolver to her purse, picked up the telephone and dialed a number from a yellow sticker plastered across the phone.

OFFICER: Merry Valley Police Department.

LINDA: *(matter of fact)* The Enforcement Handbook says I'm supposed to call you. I've just shot someone.

OFFICER: That's right. Who did you shoot? And how many times?

LINDA: My husband. Once.

OFFICER: I'd recommend you shoot him one more time just to be sure.

NARRATOR: The Enforcement Handbook recommended at least two shots, but the first shot hadn't been easy, in spite of what the handbook said.

OFFICER: Fine then, but you'll need to come down to the station to fill out the paperwork.

LINDA: Do I need to call someone to pick him up?

OFFICER: We'll take care of that. Just come down to the station and don't forget to bring your red card. And any spare ammunition you didn't use. We can reissue it with the card.

NARRATOR: Linda hung up, set the phone on the floor, and went to her bedroom. She scanned her closet and finally settled on a lavender dress and a matching pair of high heeled shoes. Linda wasn't sure who might be at the police station, but crowds had a way of forming, and she wanted to be presentable.

LINDA: Damn it, Larry, I gave you fair warning.

NARRATOR: Linda stepped into the dark night. The porch light on Sarah Hall's house across the street blazed like a beacon. Sarah gave a friendly wave. Linda liked Sarah and believed Sarah liked her too. She liked her sisterly advice. Often Linda would call Sarah when Larry acted up. As the taxi pulled over, Sarah dashed across the street, opened the taxi door and slid into the back seat; she waved for Linda to join her.

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SARAH: *(excited)* Why did you shoot him?

NARRATOR: Linda wanted to cry. The handbook had mentioned this—Shooter's Regret. It will pass, the handbook stated, just trust your decision, trust your instincts.

SARAH: When I was young, I used to drive around with my cousin. He would yell at people all the time -- for going too slow, for going too fast, for cutting him off. I wasn't surprised when he used a red card. The same week he got it, in fact.

LINDA: How'd you know I used a red card?

SARAH: I heard it on the radio. There's nothing as exciting as one of the cards being used.

NARRATOR: By the time Linda and Sarah arrived at the police station, a small crowd had already gathered.

MILES: *(cheering)* Way to go! Killed by a librarian with a red card. That's got to be embarrassing.

BARRY GILES: *(reporting with microphone in hand)* How did it happen, Mrs. Jackson?

NARRATOR: Officer Hamilton was waiting for Linda. She reached into her purse and pulled out the government-issued revolver and the red card. The card didn't seem

special. It was small, half the size of a postcard, with rounded corners. The one mark on it was an ordinary bar code. Officer Hamilton slid the card under an electronic reader, confirmed its authenticity, and led Linda to a small, secluded room in the back of the station.

LINDA: This is the hard part, isn't it?

OFFICER: There's no hard part. It's all easy. *(putting on his glasses. He begins the paperwork)* Marital Status?

LINDA: Widowed.

OFFICER: *(chuckles)* Oh yes, that's kind of why we're here, isn't it. Why did you execute the enforcement?

LINDA: I think the real question should be why didn't I do it sooner.

OFFICER: Why didn't you? You've had the red card for almost four years.

LINDA: I didn't want to use it because then I wouldn't have one. Sometimes he would egg me on, dare me to use it.

OFFICER: *(shocked)* He knew you had a red card? *(shrugs)* Just answer honestly. You have nothing to worry about. You performed an enforcement while in possession of a

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valid red card. It's that simple. These questions are just to help us improve the program.

LINDA: He knew. He's known for years. Is that alright? Am I in trouble?

OFFICER: Well, some people view it as having an unfair advantage over other citizens. But in this case it doesn't seem to have made a difference. Had he been drinking?

LINDA: He'd been out messing around. I think I just snapped.

OFFICER: Linda. People with red cards are allowed to snap. It's their duty to snap. *(putting down his pencil and removing his glasses)* That wasn't so bad was it? [But] a word of advice? If you ever get another red card, don't tell anyone. The program is random and anonymous. That's what makes it work.

NARRATOR: Officer Hamilton released Linda. As she walked down the hall to join Sarah in the waiting area, he could hear voices.

MILES: Well, I know what I'll do if I get the card next.

SARAH: If you get a card, let me know. You tend to live a lot longer if you know who has the cards.

MILES: She shops at my store. Always did like her.

SARAH: Sweetheart, you have to like someone who has a red card. Kind of dangerous not to.

MILES: How would I have known she had a red card?

SARAH: I knew. I've known it for years. I'm surprised you all didn't know. *(pausing for effect)* Oh, I forgot, **you all** weren't sleeping with her husband? *(laughing)* Well, I guess I won't **have** to like her anymore.

NARRATOR: Linda listened for the conversation to continue, but it stalled. Even Sarah was silent. She joined Sarah and the others in the waiting room.

LINDA: Sarah, I'm all done now.

NARRATOR: When the taxi dropped them off at Linda's place well after midnight, Sarah had pretty well resolved most of Linda's problems. She had told her how to improve her career–

SARAH: After all you can't stay a librarian your entire life.

NARRATOR: And she had told her how to improve her looks–

SARAH: Those bangs just have to go; they do absolutely nothing for you. Stop moping about. Tomorrow we plan Mr. Jackson's funeral. Then we bury him, and then

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you get on with your life. The enforcement program is run so well.

NARRATOR: Even the blood had been cleaned up. All that remained was a small stain, barely noticeable on the other side of the room. Sarah folded onto the couch, pried her shoes off, and clicked through the television channels.

LINDA: Stay for as long you can. I'll be with you in a moment. After I change.

(she closes the door to her bedroom softly, kicks off her shoes, folds her hands over her face, and quietly in distress – a beat, then she renews her resolve – she reaches for a shoe box, opens it slowly and pulls out a red card and a small revolver. She clears her throat and as she steels herself for what is to come, she calls out to Sarah but this time with a clear double meaning)

Sarah, I'm all done now.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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